Admitted

A free guide for college applicants

Anatomy of a winning essay.

What admissions readers look for, the five parts of an essay that works, one example taken apart line by line, and a checklist for before you hit submit.

1. What a reader is looking for

A reader has a few minutes and a stack of files.

Your grades and scores already told them what you've done. The essay is the one place they hear how you think. Six things decide whether it lands, and they're the same six Admitted rates every draft on.

Only you could have written it

Details and observations no other applicant has. If you could swap your name for a classmate's, it isn't there yet.

It sounds like a person

Plain, specific sentences in your own voice, not brochure language or thesaurus words.

It shows how you think

A real change in how you see or act, earned by what happened, not a lesson announced at the end.

The opening holds attention

The first lines put the reader inside a moment or an idea they want to follow. No quotes, no definitions.

It earns its length

Every paragraph moves it forward, and the ending lands without restating the point.

It answers the prompt

Especially for supplements: the question asked, answered throughout, not just in the last line.

Notice what isn't on the list: an impressive topic. A Saturday job can carry an essay further than a tragedy, if the thinking is yours.

2. The five parts

Most essays that work are built the same way.

1. **A moment, not a summary**
   Start inside something specific: a sound, a sentence someone said, a mistake. The reader should not know the moral yet.

2. **The detail only you have**
   The thing you noticed that someone passing through wouldn't. This is what makes the essay yours.

3. **The turn**
   The point where what you believed stopped being true, or got more complicated. Most weak essays skip this.

4. **What you do differently now**
   Show the change in action: a decision, a habit, a question you now ask. Don't name the virtue.

5. **An ending that lands**
   Return to an image or leave a question open. Never close by repeating the lesson or predicting your success.

The same idea, two ways

WEAK OPENING

Ever since I was young, I have always been passionate about helping others. As Gandhi said, "Be the change you wish to see in the world."

STRONG OPENING

The left boot always comes in worse. Mrs. Alvarez drags that foot a little, and the outside of the heel wears to a slant you can feel with your thumb before you see it.

The second gives the reader nothing to agree with and everything to wonder about. That is the job of a first line.

3. One essay, taken apart

An example, annotated.

This essay was written for this guide to show the parts in action. It is not a real applicant's essay.

The left boot always comes in worse. Mrs. Alvarez drags that foot, a little, and the outside of the heel wears to a slant you can feel with your thumb before you see it. I knew this about her before I knew her first name.

I was fifteen, and my grandfather's left hand had stopped closing the spring before, so the awl was mine now. He sat on the stool by the register and corrected me with his chin. Too deep. Again. I ruined two soles that April and paid for them out of my own envelope, which he noticed and did not mention.

What I liked, it turned out, was the ledger. Forty percent of our Saturday money came from eleven people, and I could tell you which of them walked to work. I raised the price of a heel by two dollars and told my grandfather afterward. He looked at the page for a long time, then pushed it back to me, and I still can't say whether that meant yes.

Mrs. Alvarez could buy new boots. He told me that the first year, and also that her husband had bought these ones, and I took it as a sweet fact about her. I don't anymore. I think she comes in every four months because this is a thing she can still do for him that has a beginning and an end. When I look at a business now I don't ask what it sells. I ask what its eleven people would have to do without.

Last month I told her the left heel couldn't take another nail. She thought about it. "Show me on the other one first," she said, and put her foot up on the bench.

The moment. Seven words, no context, and the reader is already inside a shop.

The detail only they have. Nobody invents "corrected me with his chin". It sounds like a person.

Specific, not impressive. A number from a ledger says more about how they think than "I learned business skills".

The turn. Four words mark where the old belief stopped being true.

What changed, in action. A question they now ask, instead of a virtue they claim.

An ending that lands. No lesson restated. A small act of trust, and the essay stops.

4. Before you submit

Ten checks for your draft.

- [ ] My first sentence puts the reader in a moment, not a summary of my life.
- [ ] There's no quote from a famous person and no dictionary definition.
- [ ] I could not swap my name for a classmate's and keep the essay true.
- [ ] Every claim about myself ("hardworking", "passionate") is shown, or cut.
- [ ] There's a point where something I believed changed, and I can underline it.
- [ ] The change shows up as something I do now, not a lesson I state.
- [ ] I read it aloud and it sounds like me talking to someone I respect.
- [ ] Each paragraph does something the one before it didn't.
- [ ] My last line doesn't repeat the lesson or predict my future success.
- [ ] It answers exactly what the prompt asked, and it's under the word limit.

Want your draft checked against all of this?

Admitted is an AI tool that rates your essay on these six criteria, marks the lines costing you most, and helps you rewrite them in your own voice. **$9.99 a week, cancel anytime.**

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